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Haunted Laughter: Spectral Justice and Satirical Memory in Percival Everett's *The Trees*

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ABSTRACT

This article reads Percival Everett's *The Trees* (2021) as a contemporary experiment in how the novel can reckon with the U.S.'s lynching archive. Focusing on the recurring mutilated corpse, the setting of Money, Mississippi, and the novel's grotesquely comic crime scenes, I argue that Everett fuses haunting and satire to stage "spectral justice": the dead return not as gothic décor but as agents who force institutions and bystanders to look again. Close readings of key episodes show how deadpan humor exposes bureaucratic denial, how the collapsing detective plot refuses easy individualized guilt, and how the closing catalog of real lynching victims converts genre closure into a memorial roll call. Bringing these narrative strategies together, the essay contends that *The Trees* functions as a metamodern countermemorial, oscillating between ridicule and care to retrain readers' attention from solving a puzzle to bearing witness to a history that will not stay buried.

Introduction

Percival Everett's *The Trees* stages a paradox: a comic procedural about racist murder that turns, inexorably, into a ghost story about national memory. Set in Money, Mississippi, the novel opens with a series of grotesque killings whose "calling card" is the inexplicable reappearance and disappearance of a mutilated Black corpse—visibly echoing the historical figure of Emmett Till—at multiple crime scenes (Everett). Rather than treating this conceit as mere shock, Everett uses the supernatural as a narrative technology of remembrance, forcing the present to meet what the nation has repeatedly refused to face. In this sense, the novel literalizes what cultural-memory theorists describe as the return of an unworked-through past: the dead do not rest because the living have not done the necessary work of reckoning (Hirsch; Davis).

Everett signals this doubleness in his very first beats. The opening line's flat verdict—"Money, Mississippi, looks exactly like it sounds" (Everett, p. 1)—works as deadpan world-building and as moral cue: Sound and sense collapse into a single, too-neat provincialism the novel will pry open. The first crime scene then piles on incongruities—domestic clutter, small-talk sarcasm, a character insisting the victim is "really, really dead" (Everett, p. 14)—until bathos becomes indictment. When the unidentified Black corpse reappears, the scene is staged like a visual joke the camera refuses to cut away from; but the "gag" is the county's, not the book's. Everett's diction pushes us to hear routine forensic language scrape against an unmanageable object whose mutilations echo Till's iconography. That tonal rub is the novel's thesis in miniature: official speech cannot metabolize what history has left unworked (Everett; Hirsch; Davis).

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Two bodies of scholarship frame the stakes and the novelty of Everett's approach. First, work on postmemory and haunting argues that traumatic histories persist as "afterlives" that shape descendants' worlds, often surfacing as spectral figures or narrative compulsions (Hirsch; Davis). African American literary criticism has long read ghosted presences as instruments for historical recovery — from Morrison's *Beloved*, wherein a revenant concentrates the afterlife of slavery (Krumholz), to fictions that mobilize haunting to contest official forgetting (Brogan). Everett extends this tradition by fusing haunting to a satirical engine: the revenant does not only wound, it ridicules the structures that enable forgetting. Second, scholarship on African American satire shows how absurdity and comedy function as dissent—means to expose the grotesque logic of racial domination without reproducing it (Maus). Everett's novel belongs to this line, but its wager is riskier: it entwines a grotesque comic tone with a lynching archive, asking readers to inhabit an unsettling space wherein laughter and mourning continually collide.

The Trees also retools genre to widen culpability. As Merivale notes, postmodern and "metaphysical" detective fictions often refuse neat solutions, converting the missing culprit into a commentary on social knowledge and shared guilt. Everett embraces and sharpens that refusal. The case cannot "close" because the crime—racial terror—was never adjudicated; the novel's procedural scaffolding finally gives way to a roll call of the dead and a march of the remembered, in which the many, not the one, return (Everett). In doing so, the book pivots from the whodunit's singular offender to the systemic: the who becomes a "we."

Situating Everett's method within his career helps clarify why this blend lands with such force. Critics have shown how Everett resists being confined to expected "Black subject matter" or stylistic boxes, leveraging satire and genre play to unsettle the market's racialized expectations (Caputa). In *The Trees*, this resistance becomes an ethics of form. The comedy does not undercut the gravity of lynching's memory; it undercuts the institutions, habits, and reading protocols that domesticate it. Read alongside recent work *Critique* has published—on postwar memory and optics (Worthington & Acharya), on feminist bodies and abjection (Miller & Fuller), and on excess detail tilting realism toward the magical (Bandyopadhyay)—Everett's novel appears as a contemporary experiment in representation: It bends tone and genre to make historical recognition unavoidable.

The article advances the following thesis: *The Trees* performs spectral justice through satirical memory. By literalizing the return of lynching's dead in a procedural frame that it ultimately breaks, Everett compels a recognition of collective guilt that conventional realism and conventional detection cannot secure. The argument proceeds in three moves. First, I show how the novel's hauntings figure cultural trauma's "return" and reassign agency to the historically silenced (Hirsch; Davis; Krumholz). Second, I demonstrate that Everett's grotesque humor belongs to a tradition of Black satirical dissent that exposes racist absurdity rather than trivializing harm (Maus; Naughton). Third, I read the book's subversion of the detective genre as a critique of individuated blame and as an insistence on structural culpability (Merivale). A brief coda situates the novel's oscillation between irony and sincerity within a metamodern affect that weds ridicule to memorial care (Vermeulen & van den Akker). Throughout, *The Trees* is treated not as a provocation for its own sake but as a countermemorial in fiction—an experiment in making the past audible, visible, and, crucially, inescapable (Metress; Everett).

"The Ghosts Won't Rest" – Historical Dissonance and Haunting in The Trees

Everett builds his novel on an image that refuses containment: a battered, unidentified Black corpse appears at one White murder scene after another in Money, Mississippi, vanishes from official custody, and then reappears elsewhere, as if history itself were circulating through the county (Everett). The procedural surface—sheriffs, deputies, forensics, file folders—cannot domesticate the phenomenon. From the outset, the book insists that the present can neither explain nor evade what it has not reckoned with. The body's recurrence is not a puzzle box to be solved by clever detection; it is a sign that the terms of the present have been set by the unworked past. The dead return because the living have not done the work of memory. In that sense, the novel

literalizes a claim shared by memory studies and spectral theory: Traumatic history does not stay behind chronological fences but returns, again and again, as a pressure on the now (Davis; Hirsch).

Haunting is the form this pressure takes. In theoretical accounts, haunting names the disturbance produced when disavowed violence is neither acknowledged nor repaired; the traces of that violence persist as specters that "address" the living and demand response (Davis). Postmemory research likewise describes how later generations inhabit affective afterlives of events they did not experience directly; they "remember" through mediated images, narratives, and inherited intensities (Hirsch). Everett's fiction operationalizes both insights. The novel's unclassifiable corpse is not a single character so much as the embodiment of a memory-demand: an insistence that the county's social world—and by extension, the nation's—recognize what its institutions have treated as residual or closed. The forensic language attached to the case teeters between the banal and the grotesque, and that tonal swing underscores the spectral logic: this is not merely a crime to be processed, it is an unaccounted-for history that has returned to demand accounting (Everett; Davis).

The disappearance from cold storage and the panicked return to forms and signatures stage, at bench height, what Gordon calls "ghostly matters": objects (drawer, tag, sheet) suddenly fail at their stabilizing work, and administrative talk sounds absurd against an absence it cannot file. The episode reads less like a clue than like an institutional self-exposure—the archive revealing its own limits when confronted by what it once refused to see (Gordon; Everett).

African American literature has a long record of staging such demands through revenants. In Morrison's *Beloved*, the ghost is the archive of slavery's unspeakable pain, a presence that both wounds and enables historical recovery (Krumholz). Brogan traces how American ethnic literatures mobilize ghosts to contest official forgetting, translating cultural loss into figures that compel attention. In *The Trees*, Everett extends this tradition but with a crucial adjustment: the revenant's function is pointedly civic. It is not only an intimate familial haunting, as in *Beloved*, but a public one pitched at the scale of the county and its institutions—police, coroners, politicians, records offices. The ghost enters the courthouse, the morgue, and the patrol car; and in doing so, converts personal memory into a pressure on bureaucratic life. The effect is to widen the ambit of haunting from household to polity, from private grief to collective recognition (Brogan; Krumholz).

When the body reappears in a domestic bathroom, tiled brightness and mirror-light turn a private room into a public reckoning. The staging instructs how postmemory works: the same figure returns in a new frame, and the ordinary scene—fixtures, steam, reflection—becomes an instrument that forces prolonged looking. Recurrence is the pedagogy; each repetition carries inherited affect back into the present (Everett; Hirsch; Davis).

That widening has consequences for agency. In lynching narratives across the twentieth century, Black victims are silenced and White impunity is institutionalized; the archive is often a sequence of euphemisms and omissions. Everett inverts the grammar. The recurring corpse forces speech acts—reports, testimonies, affidavits —that cannot stabilize the event; the authorities must narrate what they cannot assimilate. Haunting here reassigns agency to the historically silenced: the dead not only "speak," they drive plot, pace, and attention (Hirsch; Davis). The novel is thus less about who did it than about who can be made to look, and keep looking, when history rises. That redistribution of agency aligns with the broader insight, central to postmemory and spectral studies, that the return of the dead is not supernatural garnish but a political demand for recognition (Davis; Hirsch).

Everett's choice of historical referent sharpens that demand. The corpse unmistakably echoes Emmett Till—the most widely circulated icon of U.S. lynching, whose 1955 murder galvanized civil rights activism and has "haunted" African American cultural production ever since (Metress). The echo matters less as "solution" than as index: it ensures that the novel's spectral economy is anchored to a real history of terror. The recognizable markers—Mississippi geography, the repetition of a battered Black body, the stubborn refusal of the corpse to stay where authorities put it—pin the narrative to the Till archive, which in turn frames the return as an indictment of systemic memory failure (Everett; Metress). Everett thus participates in, and updates, a lineage in which Till's figure

functions as a test case for national remembrance: if even this story —photographed, reported, retold —cannot secure justice in memory, what could? (Metress; Eyerman).

To describe that indictment purely in moral or legal terms, however, would miss what haunting does as a social form. Gordon's account of "ghostly matters" emphasizes that specters materialize social injuries that have not been resolved; they make absences present in ways that alter everyday life (Gordon). *The Trees* dramatizes that alteration. Everyday routines—morning coffee at the diner, body-processing at the morgue, small-town banter—are repeatedly interrupted by a presence that institutions cannot process, a remainder that will not be converted into case-closed paperwork. The ghost is not detachable from the social setting; it saturates it. Scenes of deadpan administrative chatter are forced to share space with the unadministrable, and that friction produces the book's signature dissonance: a county that wants to run on habit finds itself re-timed by a history it cannot own (Everett; Gordon).

This retiming is crucial. Haunting scrambles chronology. Rather than moving from past to present by neat succession, the novel operates in what Davis calls a hauntological temporality, wherein "then" lives inside "now" as an insistence. Hirsch's postmemory likewise figures the present as thickened by images and affects inherited from prior violence (Hirsch). In Money, that thickness is narrated through recurrence: each attempt to reset to normal—bag the body, file the report, drive the evidence—meets the same return (Everett). The loop is not a puzzle to be broken but a lesson: Until recognition occurs, the county will be condemned to repetition. The revenant is thus a pedagogy of time, teaching that without repair, history is not behind us. It is what we are in.

If we read haunting as pedagogy, the novel's movement through institutions takes on a further meaning. The corpse's disappearance from the morgue and reappearance elsewhere is fiction's way of declaring that the archive can neither domesticate nor contain what it excludes. The problem is not an evidentiary gap that better forensics could close; it is structural refusal. The revenant's refusals —the refusal to stay refrigerated, tagged, and filed—stage literature's counterarchive, one that insists on presence against bureaucratic erasure (Everett; Gordon). Thaggert's analysis of *The Trees* underscores this point by reading Everett's long, closing catalog of lynching victims as a practice of "literary reparation": a naming that resists the state's failures to name and count (Thaggert). The revenant prepares the ground for that final list by performing, throughout the novel, the same reparative refusal: you cannot store me away; I will return until you speak.

Because Everett folds this spectral pedagogy into a procedural frame, he invites a second, formal recognition: the detective genre's ordinary commitments—to causality, closure, individual culpability —are inadequate to crimes whose very structure was collective (Merivale). The haunting makes that inadequacy visible. Each recurrence of the corpse throws the investigation back to its premise: What if the "who" is a "we" and the temporal frame of guilt is not a week of killings but a century of terror? The specter presses that reframing not by syllogism but by obstinacy; it is the failed closure that keeps happening (Everett; Merivale). In this way, haunting becomes not simply a theme but a formal critique that anticipates the novel's later refusal to deliver a conventional solution.

None of this works without the cultural memory to sustain it, and Everett writes as if that memory must be both carried and made again. Eyerman describes how slavery functions as a "cultural trauma" that shapes identity through narratives, symbols, and commemorations. Lynching, and the public spectacle that accompanied it, operates in a related register for African American memory; the persistence of its images and stories constitutes a repertoire that later art can activate for ethical ends (Eyerman; Metress). *The Trees* activates that repertoire via a double move: it reanimates the terror in the figure of the corpse and, just as importantly, reanimates recognition by forcing its White officials and bystanders to witness a scene that reverses the historical optics. What was once a ritualized public display of Black victimhood becomes, in Everett's staging, a ritualized public display of White inability to assimilate the victim's return (Everett; Eyerman). The ghost is the mirror the county cannot bear.

One might object that making the dead "active" risks aestheticizing injury. That risk is real; Thaggert names the "extreme risk" of threading comedy, spectacle, and Till's memory, and the term

applies as well to spectralization itself. But spectralization in *The Trees* is neither decorative nor sensational. It is argumentative. The revenant interrupts familiar postures—pity, denial, bureaucratic competence—and rearranges them into an encounter in which denial fails because the scene will not end. The ethical wager is that only such rearrangements can move recognition beyond sentiment to something like responsibility (Thaggert; Gordon). Spectral pressure, in other words, is not a flourish but a strategy for converting memory into obligation.

Seen across the novel, that strategy produces a pattern of address. The dead return, but not as mute symbols; they return as an insistence that the living reorder their world. In theoretical terms, haunting is an address that calls subjects into a difficult present—one thick with others' pasts—and demands a response adequate to what has been silenced (Davis; Hirsch). In Everett's terms, that address looks like procedural failure and public disquiet. The sheriff's routines become rituals of avoidance; the morgue's procedures become farce; the small-town pleasantries curdle into alibis the ghost will not honor (Everett). Every recurrence exposes the gap between what people say they know and what the place is built to forget. The ghost is the pedagogue of that gap.

By the end of this section of the argument, we can name what haunting accomplishes in *The Trees*: it transfers agency to the silenced, retimes the present with an insistently unpast past, exposes the incapacity of institutions to process what they have historically enabled, and primes the novel's formal refusal of individualized guilt. In short, the ghosts do not rest because the living have not learned. The novel ensures that the lesson will recur until recognition is forced. The next stage of the analysis turns to tone. If haunting supplies the pressure, how does Everett make readers stay with it? The answer is as unsettling as it is effective: he binds spectral pedagogy to grotesque humor, so that the return of the dead arrives with laughter that is hard to place—laughter that, as we will see, functions not as dismissal but as dissent (Maus).

"Laughter in the Dark" – Satire, Absurdity, and the Comedy of Racial Trauma

From its first scenes, *The Trees* bends the procedural toward bathos. A sheriff complains about the inconvenience of a murder, deputies trade easy quips, and a killing is treated as something that simply "ruins a day" in Money, Mississippi, even as the mise-en-scène quietly points back to lynching-era terror (Everett). The joke, however, is not on the dead. Everett's humor targets a civic world that has learned to shrug at atrocity by making routine out of it. As the same mutilated Black corpse reappears, vanishes from the morgue, and reappears again, the gag develops as repetition-with-a-memory: a farce that refuses to forget (Everett). African American satire has long drawn power from such incongruities—laughter that widens moral attention rather than diminishing it (Maus). In Everett's hands the incongruity sharpens into method: comedy becomes the delivery system for an accusation that cannot be spoken in the flat voice of procedure.

To see what is at stake, it helps to recall what scholars identify as satire's double action in Black literary traditions. First, satire estranges: it pushes readers outside well-worn scripts by exaggerating their absurdities, forcing recognition of what had been naturalized (Ruffin). Second, satire dissents: it stages critique through comic means—caricature, hyperbole, grotesque juxtapositions—while keeping ethical pressure in view (Maus, "[O]ne is lost to understand what this has to do with the [Black] experience"). *The Trees* concentrates both actions. Everett populates Money with types whose names verge on skit—Junior Junior, Wheat, Red Jetty—then has those types move through scenes wherein racist commonsense is treated as background noise. Much of the early dialogue sounds like small-town banter until it is replayed against the repeated discovery of the same brutalized body; then the casual talk reads as complicity. The humor is caustic because the noise is lynching; the town's practiced nonchalance becomes ridiculous precisely at the moment the revenant makes indifference impossible (Everett; Maus; Ruffin). In this way, comedy functions as a moral lens: it magnifies the banality of local talk until the talk indicts itself.

The novel also exploits the comic's capacity to reassign who is allowed to make meaning. In the classic lynching script, the White crowd narrates; the Black victim is rendered mute spectacle. Everett

reverses the distribution. The recurring corpse sets the rhythm of the plot, while officials falter in a haze of clichés, malapropisms, and misread clues (Everett). Every time the story seems to settle into investigative competence, the body's return punctures the illusion and exposes how little the institutions understand. The joke is procedural: each confident explanation collapses as the revenant reappears. But that joke is also ethical: the collapse marks the failure of institutions built to stabilize White impunity (Maus, "[O]ne is lost to understand what this has to do with the [Black] experience"). As Naughton observes in his reading of Beatty's *The Sellout*, outrageous comedy can "plead human" by refusing to dignify the logics that dehumanize. Everett's version "pleads human" for the dead by denying dignity to the speech acts that would tidy them away. The reader's laughter, then, is not collusion but recoil; it shames bureaucratic composure by making it ridiculous (Naughton; Everett).

A predictable objection surfaces here: can one laugh anywhere near Emmett Till? Thaggert calls Everett's wager an "extreme risk," because *The Trees* threads a lynching archive through a comic plot. The risk is not theoretical. Laughter can anesthetize; it can slide into cruelty or evasion. Everett's practice answers by calibrating joke and target. The novel reserves ridicule for perpetrators, bystanders, and systems—for the sheriff's petulance, the coroner's bluster, the mayor's instinctive PR frame—not for victims or their grief (Everett). The reappearing corpse never becomes a comic prop; it remains the interruption that cancels the town's props. If a line lands as funny, it usually punctures a posture of innocence, exposing how racism's habits survive in boilerplate and folksy talk (Maus; Thaggert). The effect is a comedy of exposure: readers laugh at the cover-up, not at the wound.

That calibration depends on tone more than thesis. Everett's tone leans deadpan, a choice that lets the grotesque speak without italicizing itself. Deadpan holds two things at once: the administrative voice that wants to move on and the spectral recurrence that quietly insists on a second look (Everett). Reports are filed, cause-of-death language is recited, and chain-of-custody routines are performed as if nothing were out of the ordinary, even when everything is. The friction between those voices generates a distinctive affect for post-Black satire's play with authenticity and stereotype. Everett "signifies" on the small-town procedural by letting it indict itself: the more its agents insist on normalcy, the more abnormal their speech sounds against the revenant's insistence. That is where laughter begins—not in dismissing harm but in hearing denial get weird (Everett). The humor is thus diagnostic: it makes audible the tonal drift of a community out of tune with its past.

Repetition, a staple of the comic, is also the novel's mnemonic engine. Each time the corpse returns, the gag resets the scene, but the reset accumulates pressure rather than relieving it (Everett). "One is lost to understand what this has to do with the [Black] experience" (Maus) notes that Black satire often uses iterative bits to worry at ideological habits until those habits fray; what once read as "how things are" begins to read as farce. Everett hinges that iterative structure to haunting's temporal logic: because the history has not been worked through, the scene must recur (Davis; Hirsch). The repetition becomes pedagogy. Readers are trained to anticipate the return—not as a punchline but as a demand to look. That training matters in a culture in which trauma's images are easily scrolled past. In *The Trees*, you cannot scroll. The same body appears again, and again, and again (Everett).

Grotesque humor pushes that pedagogy further by forcing incompatible frames together. A deputy's relaxed aside collides with the sight of a mutilated body; a coroner's grandstanding meets a vanished cadaver; an official press line runs up against a second impossible reappearance (Everett). The laugh comes late, if at all, and often with a wince. As Ruffin argues, such grotesque juxtapositions are not mischief but method: they reveal the obscene compatibility the culture has cultivated between talk and terror. In Everett's novel, this method exposes the performative ease with which officials narrate away harm. It is easy to tell the story of one murder in a tone that keeps one's lunch down; it is harder to tell the story of a century's murders when the ghost refuses your tone (Ruffin; Everett). Grotesque comedy thus disciplines narration, obliging the teller to find a voice that can bear what it says.

Naming is part of that discipline. Everett's comic onomastics—Junior Junior, "Granny C," Red Jetty—tempt a reader to hear the book as lampoon. But the names do not cheapen the charge; they concentrate it. The silliness of Junior Junior stains quickly when aligned with casual cruelty and

inherited power; the name marks a genealogy that cannot stop naming itself into authority even as the past knocks (Everett). Maus reminds us—"[O]ne is lost to understand what this has to do with the [Black] experience"—that satire's surface exaggeration often hides a sober sociology: types are made to show typecasting. In Money, types reproduce themselves across time, and the comic name is the label on a file drawer that will not close. The laughter is the sound of the drawer forced open by a hand the living did not expect (Maus; Everett).

Because the town is rendered as a chorus of recognizable voices, the novel also exploits comic timing. Exchanges ping between lawmen and locals with a rhythm lifted from sitcom and sketch, only to be undercut by the corpse's reappearance (Everett). That undercutting is structurally akin to what Naughton hears in *The Sellout*: joke as trapdoor. We step onto the plank of a familiar bit and plunge into a shaft the bit was laid to cover. In *The Trees*, the shaft has a name: America's lynching archive. The comic timing makes the fall felt; the floor gives way at the beat wherein lightness was expected. The form thus trains a reader to distrust the beat, to read past it into the dark (Naughton; Everett). As a pedagogy of attention, this is ruthless and effective.

Satire also lets Everett redraw the map of complicity. Comedy is social; it distributes who is "in" on the bit. In Money, White officials imagine themselves the only audience that matters; they perform for one another, polishing lines that keep the town intact. Everett rewires the circuit. The novel's implied audience is offstage and historical—the dead who return, the larger public beyond the county, the reader asked to refuse the town's "we" (Everett). Maus reads contemporary Black satire as tinkering with in-group and out-group address to unsettle identity expectations; that is what happens here. The county talks to itself; the book talks over it. The effect is to isolate the town's laughter, making it sound cramped, cruel, and small. Readers are invited to laugh elsewhere: at the cramped laughter and at the system it props up (Maus).

None of this comic architecture would carry if the novel were not anchored to a specific trauma. Everett's humor works because it is tethered to a record of violence that scholarship identifies as a cultural trauma—lynching as an injury that shapes identities and memories across generations (Eyerman; Metress). That tethering is explicit: the figure of Emmett Till is everywhere and nowhere, invoked by the corpse's iconography and by Mississippi's geography, yet never reduced to a simple solution to a whodunit (Everett; Metress). In this respect the book's laughter is historical craft. It depends on readers knowing, or learning, what the town has chosen to forget. Comedy here is not a tool for evasion but for instruction: it cues recognition, then compels it to stay.

If the ethical question is whether satire risks trivializing harm, Everett answers by transposing the register of harm from content to form. The harm that comedy inflicts in *The Trees* is not upon victims but upon the narrative habits that protect perpetrators and bystanders. Lines that might be "funny" in a different novel—small-town sarcasm, officious blather—are turned into self-incriminating exhibits by the revenant's recurrence (Everett). The book thus practices what Thaggert calls "literary reparation" elsewhere in its structure: it repairs attention. By refusing to let the comic line do what it usually does—clear the palate, ease the mood—the novel repurposes laughter as memory's instrument. The giggle becomes a flinch; the punchline returns as a name.

A final feature of Everett's comedic dissent is restraint. No one delivers a thesis against racism; no omniscient narrator lectures the town. The satire trusts readers to feel how tone goes wrong in the presence of the dead. "[O]ne is lost to understand what this has to do with the [Black] experience" (Maus) stresses that much late-century and contemporary African American satire works by inference: it lets structure, surface, and scene do the indicting. *The Trees* refines that trust through pacing and silence. The book often cuts away where an earnest novel might linger—or lingers where an earnest novel might cut away (Everett). Those choices create the unsettled space in which laughter and mourning coexist without canceling each other. In that space, denial becomes unintelligible.

What emerges, then, is a comic grammar precisely tailored to a haunted world. Everett's jokes police the living, not the dead; they throw doubt on institutional language not on testimony from the grave. The humor estranges habit, redistributes agency, punctures bureaucratic composure, and reassigns audience. It does so while keeping the lynching archive visible as anchor and horizon

(Eyerman; Metress; Thaggert). If the revenant gives *The Trees* its pressure, satire gives it traction: readers keep moving not despite the discomfort but because the laughter shows where comfort has been purchased at memory's expense (Maus; Ruffin). That traction will matter for what follows. In the next movement, the novel turns its comic and spectral energies against the detective form itself, refusing the neat closure that would return the county to "normal." The joke that never lands becomes, finally, a case that cannot close (Merivale; Everett).

"Whodunit to Who Did It"—Subverting the Detective Genre and Exposing Collective Guilt

From its opening crime scene, *The Trees* borrows the furniture of the procedural—tape around a yard, numbered evidence markers, morgue drawers waiting for labels—only to estrange it. The familiar promise of the genre is that the world can be repaired by reconstructing a causal chain and naming a culprit. Everett lets that promise run for a few chapters, as sheriffs and state investigators move through the motions of bagging, logging, and filing, then pulls it apart by introducing a body that will not stay put and a case that refuses to stabilize into evidence, motive, and confession (Everett). What begins as a whodunit is rekeyed, scene by scene, into a meditation on who, historically and structurally, did it. The pivot is not announced; it is enacted. Every time the mutilated Black corpse disappears from official custody and reappears elsewhere, the investigation is dragged back into a past that paperwork was designed to close. Each bureaucratic attempt at finality is made risible by recurrence. In formal terms, Everett places the detective plot under pressure from haunting; in ethical terms, he refuses the genre's default individualism in favor of a reckoning with collective guilt and cultural trauma (Davis; Hirsch; Eyerman).

Critical accounts of the postmodern or "metaphysical" detective story help clarify how Everett's detours function. Patricia Merivale argues that contemporary fictions often retain detective conventions while undoing their teleology: the case becomes a quest without solution, clues proliferate into noise, and the detective's search reveals not a culprit but a gap in knowledge that points beyond the individual crime to a crisis in the culture that produced it (Merivale). Sweeney and Merivale further describe how such narratives "detect texts" rather than criminals—reading the world's signs only to find that the center will not hold (Sweeney & Merivale). *The Trees* fits this pattern and radicalizes it. The "text" to be detected is the archive of racist terror in the United States—lynching's photographic and oral record, its euphemisms and silences—and the center that will not hold is the procedural assumption that guilt can be confined to a single agent. Each report, each autopsy, each scene sketch brushes against a history that cannot be reduced to one episode. Everett stages detective work as a ritual whose reassuring outcome cannot be reached because the crime under investigation is not episodic; it is historical and ongoing (Merivale; Sweeney & Merivale; Eyerman).

That historical scale is embedded in the novel's casting and pacing. The Mississippi Bureau of Investigation sends in two Black detectives, Ed and Jim, whose outsider–insider status allows them to move through Money with both professional composure and sardonic distance (Everett). Early scenes show them doing textbook work—walking perimeters, asking routine questions, comparing notes—but the narrative promptly denies them the genre's usual reward structures. Scenes fail to accumulate into a solvable puzzle because the puzzle keeps rewriting itself; the corpse they have just logged vanishes from a drawer, a new body appears with the same impossible companion, and the timelines they try to straighten buckle under the pressure of repetition (Everett). Townspeople's testimonies arrive as a tangle of deflection, cant, and racist habit rather than as usable evidence. Within the terms Merivale outlines, the detectives are set to fail—not because they lack skill but because their brief is mismatched to the scale of the offense (Merivale). The unsolvable here is not a puzzle's cleverness; it is a system's longevity. Failure, in other words, becomes demystified: it reads not as the detective's limit but as the limit of the form when confronted with structural crime.

Everett underscores that limit by having the case's "facts" repeatedly decompose into farce. The coroner blusters about expertise, the sheriff postures for local audiences, a mayor frets over public

relations, and deputies lean on routine. The script is familiar from small-town crime fiction, but *The Trees* uses it to shame the script itself. Each professional gesture toward closure—attaching a cause of death, notifying next of kin, preserving a chain of custody—is neutralized by the revenant's reappearance, and the neutral tone of paperwork begins to sound absurd in the presence of an unpast past (Everett). The genre's belief that enough inference will yield a culprit gives way to the recognition that inference cannot convert a century of racial terror into an individual case file (Merivale; Davis). What the detective plot discovers, finally, is not who killed one man in Money but which polity built and maintained conditions in which such killings could be ritualized and then forgotten (Eyerman).

When readers trained by crime fiction ask, implicitly, "Who benefits from the murders?" Everett answers by withholding the answer that would restore equilibrium. There is no mastermind to unmask, no singular villain whose removal would return the town to order. Instead, the novel moves, inexorably, toward a break in the procedural: the closing pages trade the expected denouement for a roll call of names—real lynching victims, documented and remembered—after which a mass of the dead rise and move (Everett; Thaggert). The substitution is pointed. In place of the genre's consoling identification scene, Everett offers a memorial; in place of a confession, a catalog; in place of the final click of causality, a collective procession. As Thaggert notes, the list functions as "literary reparation," addressing the state's failure to name and count by performing an act of naming that is also an accusation (Thaggert). The detective story's energies—attention to detail, care for sequence, insistence on who did what when—are not discarded but redirected. They are repurposed into an ethics of enumeration that makes the ledger itself the climactic scene (Everett; Thaggert).

The novel's long joke about the case that will not close thus becomes a theory of justice that refuses closure when closure would be unjust. This refusal corresponds to spectral theory's account of how unresolved violence persists as a demand that cannot be domesticated by narrative finish (Davis). It also corresponds to postmemory's insistence that later generations live in histories they did not choose, histories whose images press on the present (Hirsch). In Money, the detectives can no more "close" the case than the nation can turn the page on lynching without substantive repair; any attempt to do so will be haunted by returns. The metaphysical detective story's emblematic gestures—dissolving clues, absent centers, labyrinthine leads—are here anchored to a specific archive of racial terror, which is why the refusal to explain feels less like a postmodern game and more like a sober recognition of scale (Merivale; Metress).

Everett sharpens that recognition by parodying the genre's fetish for a single decisive clue. In orthodox detection, the "smoking gun" or perfect fingerprint functions as guarantor of truth and instrument of closure; it allows the detective to narrate a neat arc from crime to perpetrator to punishment. *The Trees* supplies no such object, and the closest thing to a recurring sign is the reappearing corpse itself—a sign that points not to one perpetrator but to a pattern of perpetrators distributed across decades (Everett). The revenant's very materiality—the battered face, the brutalized body—acts as counterevidence to the evidentiary logic of the whodunit: the body does not tell the detectives who this time; it tells the county which time it is implicated in, again (Metress). In this inversion, the genre's prized clue becomes an accusation against the genre's appetite for singularity and against a culture that prefers isolated "cases" to structural responsibility.

The book's use of detectives of color further complicates the form's politics. Crime fiction has frequently cast Black characters as suspects, sidekicks, or settings but not as epistemic centers. By making Ed and Jim the novel's sober instruments of inquiry, Everett places Black intelligence and perspective at the core of a narrative that indicts White bureaucratic complacency (Everett). Yet he does not saddle them with an impossible salvific burden. They do not solve what cannot be solved; they register what cannot be ignored. Their professionalism, humor, and exasperation stabilize the reader's experience as the plot abandons conventional causality. In this respect, they are less restorers of order than witnesses to an order's exposure. The respect the narrative accords them—measured dialogue, procedural competence—contrasts sharply with the town's carnival of denial, reinforcing the sense that the failure belongs to the form and the system, not to these detectives (Merivale; Naughton).

Because the novel's central "case" is historical, *The Trees* also rewrites the function of testimony. In courtroom and detective scripts, testimony is the means by which the past is translated into a record fit for judgment. Everett dramatizes how, under Jim Crow and its legacies, testimony about anti-Black violence failed to yield justice, not because witnesses could not speak, but because institutions declined to hear. The revenant returns as an anti-institutional witness who cannot be cross-examined away (Everett; Eyerman). In the book's final architecture, witness piles on witness —names accrue—until the burden of recognition shifts decisively from the dead to the living. The detective plot becomes a pedagogy of listening: it instructs readers to receive a chorus, not a confession (Thaggert; Metress).

If we accept Merivale's claim that postmodern detective fiction frequently discovers the absence of any single authoritative explanation (Merivale), Everett's addition is to locate that absence not only in textual play but in the historical record of state-sanctioned forgetting. The missing piece in Money is not motive, means, or opportunity; it is justice. And because justice has been withheld across generations, the genre's clock cannot strike its reassuring hour. Hauntology supplies a name for this temporal stall, in which past violence refuses to synchronize with present narratives (Davis). Postmemory supplies a name for the affective residue that makes such refusal legible in the lives of those who came later (Hirsch). *The Trees* makes both conditions palpable by letting the apparatus of the whodunit grind against a case whose only honest outcome is the exposure of its own inadequacy (Merivale; Metress).

The ethical dividend of this formal argument is clear. In a culture that often seeks therapeutic "closure," Everett withholds it to insist on responsibility. The reader is denied the narcotic satisfaction of the arrest and is given, instead, the sober work of remembrance and implication. That substitution aligns the novel with what Eyerman calls the work of cultural trauma: building narratives and practices that allow a collectivity to acknowledge and integrate injuries it has disavowed (Eyerman). It also aligns the novel with the memorial turn in contemporary public culture—the demand to say names, to count losses, to refuse euphemism—as a precondition of any credible justice (Metress; Thaggert). The detective story's craft of patient attention thus becomes, under Everett's hand, a civic craft: the habit of attending to what power would prefer to misfile.

Finally, the novel's refusal to restore order places new weight on the reader's role. In conventional crime fiction, readers collaborate with the detective, gathering clues, testing hypotheses, anticipating the unmasking. Here, readers are asked to collaborate in a different way: to inventory the archive, to hear the chorus of the dead, to resist the seductions of explanation that would let the town and the nation off the hook. The last pages choreograph that collaboration by making the act of reading feel like an act of bearing witness—name after name, the tempo of enumeration pulling the eye forward until the catalog overwhelms the desire for plot (Everett). In that moment, the genre's energy has been wholly transformed. What mattered as a puzzle becomes matter for mourning; what counted as case detail becomes a ledger of harm. The reader is not invited to applaud the detective's brilliance; the reader is recruited to remember (Sweeney & Merivale; Thaggert).

The Trees does not reject the detective genre so much as use it to demonstrate the impossibility of solving structural crime with individualist tools. By staging procedural failure as a function of historical scale, Everett turns a whodunit into an inquiry into who we are and where responsibility resides when the dead will not stay in their files. The novel's spectral returns make the investigative present inseparable from an accusatory past (Davis; Hirsch). Its catalog of names replaces the climactic unmasking with a communal act of recognition (Thaggert). And its Black detectives, steady and unillusioned, guide readers through a genre's collapse without letting the culture off the hook (Everett; Merivale). The next stage of the argument turns to affect. If the form refuses closure, what keeps the book from despair? The answer lies in a metamodern oscillation between irony and sincerity that allows ridicule to coexist with memorial care, producing not nihilism but a chastened, durable hope (Vermeulen & van den Akker).

"Reckoning and Reconciliation?"—the Metamodern Affect of *The Trees*

Critics often describe contemporary art's mood as a swing between postmodern irony and renewed sincerity, a "both/and" structure of feeling that Tim Vermeulen and Robin van den Akker call metamodernism (Vermeulen & van den Akker). *The Trees* is saturated with that oscillation at the level of scene and sentence. A sheriff who complains that murder "ruin[s] a day" because of the paperwork stands only a few pages away from the first impossible return of the corpse; a coroner cracks jokes over a mangled body even as the narrative has already signaled the echo of Emmett Till (Everett). These juxtapositions refuse to choose between ridicule and memorial care. On one axis, Everett's deadpan satire punctures the bureaucratic poise and civic denial that let racist terror endure; on the other, the novel insists on the gravity of what returns—lynching's unquiet dead and the real histories they name (Everett). The result is an affective braid: laughter that exposes, mourning that steadies, and a rhythm that alternates without neutralizing either pole. Where postmodern parody might keep the ethical stakes at arm's length, *The Trees* lets irony and sincerity co-occupy the crime scene, teaching readers to hear how tone itself becomes an ethical instrument (Vermeulen & van den Akker; Maus).

That co-occupation is audible in the novel's handling of voice across specific episodes. In one early investigation, the procedural lexicon—cause of death, chain of custody, next of kin—arrives with the brisk rhythms of a genre built to restore order, and Everett plays that cadence for humor by letting officials grouse about inconvenience while a mutilated Black body lies in front of them (Everett). Yet the same pages are haunted by a countercadence: the revenant's recurrence, the stubborn reappearance of a body that refuses administrative finality. Irony splits the surface; sincerity deepens the ground. The satirical charge lies in showing how quickly official language becomes absurd when history speaks in the present tense; the sincere charge lies in tethering that absurdity to a record of violence that is not comic at all (Maus; Ruffin). The metamodern effect is not a compromise between moods but a relay: irony hands the scene to witness, and witness sends it back to irony, until the reader's expectations about what a crime story can feel like have been retrained (Vermeulen & van den Akker).

Everett's tonal relay also recalibrates audience position by staging who gets to hear what. Twenty-first-century African American satire, as Maus notes, "signifies" on authenticity by playing with who is addressed, who is excluded, and who must listen from the doorway (Maus). *The Trees* uses that play to unsettle complicity: the town's inside jokes grow cramped, even cruel, as the revenant keeps forcing the frame wider, and the implied audience shifts from the sheriff's cohort to the dead who return and to readers invited to refuse the town's "we" (Everett). Scenes in which lawmen trade one-liners over the corpse read differently once the narrative has taught us to hear the dead as present addressees, not absent objects. The oscillation matters here because it teaches a double habit: to laugh at the protocols that protect forgetting and to attend to the names that memory requires. Irony exposes the speech that keeps history at bay; sincerity installs a counterspeech—the cadence of naming—that keeps history close (Ruffin; Thaggert).

That cadence culminates in the novel's ending, which abandons the procedural denouement for a memorial catalog and a march of the remembered. In the records room at Mama Z's house, Damon Thruff types names "one name at a time," while outside a mass of the dead moves toward town like weather, chanting, "Rise" (Everett). The list operates at once as documentation and as ritual. Where the detective story would reveal the culprit and restore equilibrium, Everett's roll call refuses restoration, asking the reader to dwell in enumeration as an ethical act (Merivale; Thaggert). The metamodern blend is stark: the preceding comedy has stripped away institutional alibis; the list then installs a solemn counterpractice of attention. To borrow Vermeulen and van den Akker's idiom, the scene oscillates "between" not to cancel tension but to hold it—laughter did its severing work, now naming does its suturing work (2010). In that sense, the novel's sincerity is not sentimental closure; it is a discipline of looking and saying, contiguous with contemporary public rituals that insist we "say their names" as a precondition for justice (Lebron; Thaggert).

The discipline matters because *The Trees* situates affect within a larger ecology of cultural memory rather than within individual feeling alone. Ron Eyerman's account of cultural trauma emphasizes that collective injuries are carried by narratives, symbols, and commemorations that must be continually renewed (Eyerman). Everett aligns fiction with that renewal by showing how tone can either muffle or amplify memory. In the world of Money, satire loosens the grip of habitual talk so that commemoration can be heard; the revenant's interruptions pry open a space where enumeration can be received not as data but as duty (Everett; Eyerman). The metamodern texture—the alternation of deflating humor and earnest memorial—thus does more than stylize grief: it models how contemporary literature can resocialize attention. If the past has been misfiled, the book teaches a new filing practice: Attach laughter to the alibi, attach quiet to the name.

To keep that modeling from hardening into piety, Everett preserves a current of irreverence even in serious scenes. The irreverence is not toward the dead; it is toward the genres and bureaucracies that would tidy them away. Derek Maus notes that contemporary Black satire functions as dissent by "highlighting and problematizing" the ideological habits that distribute harm (Maus, Satire, comedy, and critique p. 147). *The Trees* extends that highlighting into the affective register: it lets readers feel the moment when a quip tips into an indictment because the revenant has made the quip impossible to finish (Everett). Irony here is not a hedge against feeling; it is the tool that clears rhetorical debris so feeling can land. Sincerity is not an abandonment of critique; it is critique's end, the moment in which recognition becomes inescapable (Vermeulen & van den Akker; Maus, "[O]ne is lost to understand what this has to do with the [Black] experience").

This metamodern pacing—scrape away, then settle—prevents two opposite failures. On one side lies postmodern drift, in which irony becomes an end in itself and the ethical object blurs; on the other lies moral didacticism, in which solemnity hardens into cliché. Everett skirts both by binding each mood to work the other cannot do. The jokes keep institutional speech from reasserting itself; the memorial keeps comedy from turning defense mechanism (Ruffin). The resulting affect is chastened hope rather than triumph. The novel offers no reconciliation in the legal sense—no verdict, no restored order—but it does stage a reparative possibility: a community that, having been made to hear, might begin to answer differently (Everett; Eyerman).

Answering differently, the book suggests, begins with who counts as a witness and how witnessing feels. In *The Trees*, Black investigators hold the investigative center without being tasked with delivering an impossible cure; their steadiness anchors readers as the plot refuses closure (Everett). That anchoring is part of the novel's sincere register, a refusal to caricature Black competence in the very pages that caricature White denial. But the final witness is not a character; it is the names themselves, printed line after line. The list does not reconcile; it obliges. It transforms readers' role from puzzle-solvers into bearers of record, a shift consistent with Eyerman's view that the work of cultural trauma is not to erase pain but to incorporate it into public consciousness (Eyerman; Thaggert). If reconciliation is imaginable here, it is not between detective and culprit but between a society and its archive—an acknowledgment that could ground change beyond the page (Lebron).

That imagination is contemporary in another sense. Vermeulen and van den Akker argue that metamodern works oscillate not because they are indecisive but because the world they register is ambivalent—saturated with competing demands that cannot be resolved by choosing one tone (2010). *The Trees* registers a United States that laughs at its own scripts and mourns what those scripts hid; its tonal switching is fidelity to that ambivalence. The laughter is a tactic against denial; the mourning is a tactic against forgetting. In the context of recent movements for racial justice, that pair feels less like an abstract aesthetic experiment than like a civic vernacular —sharpened talk and shared silence—as communities debate monuments, curricula, and the public forms of grief (Lebron). Everett's novel participates in that debate by showing how form makes feeling public: how a crime plot can become a countermemorial, how a joke can make room for a name (Merivale; Thaggert).

Because the book's tonal economy is so tightly engineered, it also clarifies what literature can and cannot do. It cannot prosecute; it cannot repair law; it cannot resurrect. But it can alter the distribution of attention and the habits of speech through which communities narrate themselves. In *The Trees*,

that alteration hinges on affect: the reader learns to distrust procedural calm and to trust enumerative gravity. By the end, the novel's metamodern weave has trained a reflex. When denial speaks, we listen for the revenant's footfall; when names accrue, we lower our voice (Everett; Vermeulen & van den Akker). That training is why the book's refusal of reconciliation does not read as despair. It reads as preface: a preparation of sense and feeling for the work beyond the page.

What follows from this reading is not a claim that satire and sincerity harmonize into an easy optimism. Rather, *The Trees* finds a durable affect under pressure—an ethics of attention—by running the current between ridicule and care. In doing so, it exemplifies how contemporary fiction can meet historical trauma without retreating to either posture alone. Its metamodern affect is not a style point; it is the condition under which memory can move. That is why the final affect is not catharsis but continuance: an insistence that laughter keep cutting away the false and that naming keep assembling what must be faced (Maus; Thaggert; Lebron). If *reconciliation* is still too strong a word for what the novel permits, reckoning is not. The text has already begun it.

Conclusion—"Say Their Names": Contemporary Fiction as Countermemorial

The Trees asks, very concretely, what a novel can do when official archives and legal forums have failed. Its answer is not to emulate the court or the commission but to become a countermemorial: to make the past audible and stubborn in the present until habits of looking and listening change (Everett). Across this essay I have argued that Everett fuses spectral justice with satirical memory to press that change. The revenant's repeated appearances at fresh crime scenes figure the "return" of unworked history familiar to hauntology and postmemory—an insistence that the dead address the living and require a response (Davis; Hirsch). Comedy then trains that response, stripping institutional speech of its false composure so that recognition can take hold (Maus; Ruffin). Finally, the detective frame, bent beyond closure as Ed and Jim's investigation dissolves into an unfinishable case, redirects the genre's appetite for singular culprits toward an ethics of enumeration and collective implication, culminating in Mama Z's list and the closing procession of the dead (Merivale; Thaggert).

If those elements risk pulling in different directions, the novel's metamodern affect holds them together. Irony does the severing work—cutting through denial with deadpan exchanges in the morgue and the sheriff's office—while sincerity does the suturing work, installing rituals of attention in scenes where Damon Thruff types names "one name at a time" and the dead rise, chanting, toward town (Everett). The point is not catharsis. Everett withholds the procedural satisfactions that would return Money, Mississippi, to order because the offense at issue is not episodic but historical and structural. In Eyerman's terms, such injuries are carried culturally; they require practices that renew memory rather than stories that terminate it (Eyerman). *The Trees* offers one such practice: Make the name the scene, and let the scene recur. In that sense, the novel's metamodern oscillation—between satire and memorial—provides the affective glue that keeps spectral justice, grotesque humor, and a broken whodunit in the same frame (Vermeulen & van den Akker; Thaggert).

For readers, and for classrooms, this has concrete consequences. The novel refashions the work a crime plot asks us to do. We are not puzzle-solvers awaiting a brilliant reveal; we are bearers of record, asked to receive a chorus rather than a confession as the closing catalog of lynching victims displaces the conventional unmasking scene (Everett; Merivale). That role aligns literary reading with public practices of remembrance that have gathered force in the past decade: to say names, to count losses, to refuse euphemism as a precondition of any credible justice (Lebron; Thaggert). In that sense, Everett's artistic wager is civic as well as aesthetic. By binding laughter to the alibi—making bureaucratic jokes self-indicting—and quiet to the name, the book resocializes attention, teaching a reflex of doubt toward procedural calm and a reflex of care toward the enumerated dead (Everett; Maus).

None of this claims more than literature can bear. A novel cannot prosecute, repair law, or resurrect. But it can redistribute who speaks, who is heard, and how long we must listen. On that measure, *The Trees* succeeds. It grants agency to the silenced through recurrence; it exposes the inadequacy of individualized blame for structural crime by letting the detective form collapse under

the weight of lynching's history; it models an affective discipline adequate to mourning without abandoning critique, moving readers between spectral unease, bitter laughter, and a chastened attentiveness (Davis; Merivale; Vermeulen & van den Akker). If reconciliation remains too strong a word for what the text permits, reckoning is not. Everett's countermemorial does not let the file close. It keeps the case open in the only way that matters here: by compelling readers to hold the names and, holding them, to ask what forms of justice beyond the page might finally answer their return (Everett; Eyerman).

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